BOOKS

A STEPPE IN TIME

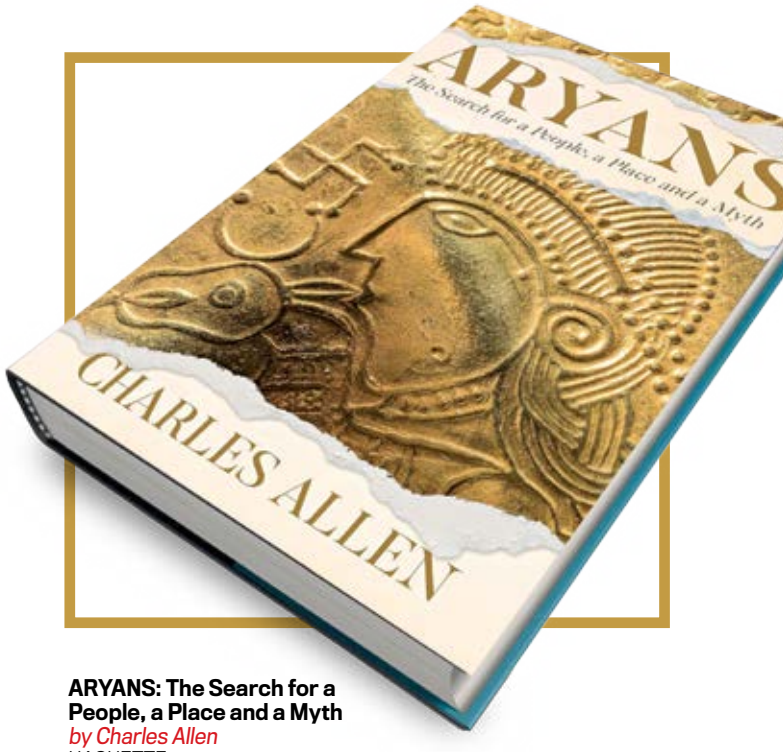
The late historian Charles Allen's last book—*Aryans*—delves into the origins of these enigmatic peoples and the controversies surrounding them

Charles Allen's *Aryans: The Search for a People, a Place and a Myth* is a tour de force survey of the latest that we know about these enigmatic people, informed by linguistics, history, archaeology and, now, genetics. Born in Kanpur in 1940 as the sixth generation of a family of British officials in India, Allen developed a life-long interest in the Indian subcontinent. *Aryans* was his swan song, the culmination of a lifetime of fascination with these long-lost people and an abiding interest in their origins. He died in 2020, with the book unedited. That task was left to Allen's collaborator David Loyn, who insists he has made no original contribution to the text.

Due to the reality that in the 19th century, Sanskrit was arguably the oldest recorded Indo-European language, the speculation around the homeland of these peoples often focused on Central and South Asia. Aryans or *Arya* was, of course, the name of the early Indian Indo-Europeans, and 19th-century scholars assumed that this was the original endonym. In the early 20th century, these ideas about Aryans synthesised with the regnant white supremacist ideology to produce a race science which theorised that blond supermen were civilisation-bearers across the world, from India to England. The most horrible mutation of these ideas became part and parcel of Nazi ideology, rendering the study of Aryans toxic for generations.

But, as Allen notes, the term 'Aryans' does not apply to the Indo-European peoples as a whole. Rather, it was the endonym of the Indo-Iranian peoples, from the Persians of Iran and the Indo-Aryan speakers of northern India, to the early steppe nomads like the Scythians. To this day, one of the largest tribes of the Ossetians of the North Caucasus, descendants of steppe Iranians, call themselves *Iron*, a term directly descended from Aryan. But the ancestors of the other Indo-European peoples, including the Germans, did not call themselves Aryans.

Today, we know far more about the Aryans than we did a century ago, thanks to the advances of scholarship, which allow researchers to clear up mysteries and bring clarity to what were muddled questions. A century of archaeology culminated after World War II in the work of Marija Gimbutas and her students and intellectual heirs like J.P. Mallory and David Anthony in fixing the origin of the early Indo-Europeans, and, therefore, the Aryans, among the *kurgans* of the Eurasian steppe. These imposing burials reflected a hierarchical society that seemed to lionise powerful men, and their rapidity in migration from one end of Eurasia to the other implied domestication of animals and perfection of the nomadic lifestyle. The best data today from archaeology, linguistics and genetics suggest that the early Aryans were a branch of Indo-Europeans who migrated eastward out of the Corded War Culture of Poland and Belorussia, eventually reaching the Urals and diversifying



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